said to have said, is that ‘I am the servant of a mere mortal, and not of an eggplant’.

It may be he meant that, unlike an eggplant which fruits all year long, a mortal must one day die;[22] and that Abul Fazl was taking advantage of a temporary turn of events in his favour. Badauni, who reports this story, had little sympathy for the ‘imbecile old men’ thus rebuffed by his colleague. Badauni’s grouse was not with conservative Muslim scholars being challenged – he was a Mahdawi too, after all, like Shaikh Mubarak. What troubled Badauni was Abul Fazl’s wilful acceptance of heretical and blasphemous creeds. Once, in fact, ‘in the early days of these discussions’, Badauni had a private argument with Abul Fazl, asking why he was so willing to challenge the truths of Islam. In the end, it seems, Abul Fazl only said, ‘I wish to wander for a few days in the vale of infidelity for sport’, and walked away, smiling.

For Badauni, Abul Fazl was the cynical manipulator playing with the mind of an emperor ‘who was possessed of an excellent disposition . . . but very ignorant’ and ‘used to the company of infidels and base persons’, thus throwing him ‘into perplexity, till doubt was heaped upon doubt’.

Doubt is the bane of the believer, but was it, for Akbar, the very horse that took him hunting for the Truth? Abul Fazl acknowledges that the Ibadat Khana made many people very unhappy, particularly those who ‘were disgraced and disappeared into obscurity’ – and this was so, he writes, because Akbar favoured debates based on ‘reason’, not ‘blind tradition’. Reason and the audacity to question, these were the weapons of Akbar’s new conquest, and Abul Fazl was his arms-bearer. For all the insults heaped upon the courtier by his fellows at the time – a popular pun on his name was ‘Fazlah’, garbage[23] – for all the accusations of flattery that have followed him through the centuries, it was Abul Fazl who articulated one of the foundational principles of Akbar’s rule, and indeed a defining tenet of the distant future.

‘They do not know,’ he wrote of the hapless men floundering in the waves of ideas washing across the Ibadat Khana, ‘that much of acquired learning is subject to doubt and scepticism’.[24]

There is little that exists in the modern world, from its politics to its medicine, that does not owe itself to this truth.